RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Peer Pressure on Self-Comparison in First-Year University Students

How students compare themselves with classmates in their first year, and what can help.

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CONTEXT

The first year changes who students compare with

At school, students knew where they stood. At university, nobody knows yet. That is what turns classmates into the new measuring stick.

TRANSITION

A new school, a new start

Grades, study habits and friends all have to be built again.

DIVERSITY

Classmates are very different

Money, looks, study background and results differ much more than in one high school.

EXPOSURE

Comparison never stops

Social media shows classmates' best moments every day, even outside class.

Xiong et al. (2026) followed 317 first-year students every day for 30 days.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

The pressure is often not said out loud

> *Everyone is moving forward. Only I am standing still.*

Nobody tells a first-year student to catch up. They guess it from the scholarships, internships and high GPAs they see in class and online, then judge themselves by that guess.

1. Peer pressure is indirect. It works through what students think the group expects.
2. Looking up at people who seem better becomes a habit.
3. Self-worth starts to depend on other people's results, not on your own progress.

Past studies show these things happen together, not that one causes the other. This study looks at that gap.

OBJECTIVE AND RESEARCH QUESTIONS

What this study wants to answer

OBJECTIVE

To study how peer pressure and self-comparison are connected in first-year students.

RQ 1	How does peer pressure affect self-comparison in first-year students?
RQ 2	Which matters more, social media use or study results?

THEORY

Social Comparison Theory

> *People want to know how they are doing. When there is no clear standard, they compare themselves with other people.*

UPWARD

Comparing with people who seem better

Can push you to try harder, but can also make you feel not good enough.

DOWNWARD

Comparing with people who seem worse

Feels better for a short time, but gives no direction.

LATERAL

Comparing with people like you

The most common type in one class: same year, same major, same start.

Festinger, L. (1954). A theory of social comparison processes. *Human Relations, 7*(2), 117–140.

PEER PRESSURE IN THE FIRST YEAR

Why first-year students feel it most

BELONGING

Wanting to fit in and be accepted

Students think their classmates do more than they really do. Found in 23 studies with 53,825 people.

$Z = .342$

Borsari & Carey (2003)

SENSITIVITY

Caring about what classmates think

What classmates think matters a lot while students are still finding their place in a new group.

3,600+

Ages 10 to 30 · Steinberg & Monahan (2007)

INDIRECT INFLUENCE

Pressure comes through group rules

Real peer influence on behaviour is small but steady, across 233 results from 60 studies.

$\beta = .08$

Giletta et al. (2021)

IMPLICATION

Real peer influence is small, but what students imagine about others is much bigger. Most of the pressure comes from that picture, not from the group.

EFFECT ON MENTAL HEALTH

One in three first-year students has a mental health problem

31%

in the last 12 months. Based on 13,984 students at 19 universities in 8 countries. The rate is 43.3% in Australia and 19.1% in Belgium, so we cannot copy Western numbers to Vietnam.

Major depression	18.5%
Anxiety disorder	16.7%
Any problem, ever	35%

They also study worse and are less happy with life.

HOW IT MAY WORK

Comparison pressure → long stress → anxiety and depression. Studies show these happen together. This study looks at whether one leads to the other.

Auerbach et al. (2018). *Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 127*(7), 623–638.

OUR METHOD

How we plan to do the study

PARTICIPANTS

200 first-year students

From universities in Vietnam, for example FPT and NEU.

INSTRUMENTS

Survey and interviews

An online questionnaire with 1 to 5 rating scales, plus interviews to explain the numbers.

ANALYSIS

Statistics software

We look for a link between peer pressure and self-comparison, then compare it with what students say in interviews.

This design shows a link between two things, not that one causes the other.

WHAT WE THINK WE WILL FIND

What we expect to find

HYPOTHESIS	Social media use makes comparison pressure stronger. Xiong et al. (2026), 317 students in their first 30 days
VIETNAM	In Vietnam, family expectations add to peer pressure, so students carry two pressures at once.
EXPECTED	To find out how much pressure students can take before it stops helping them.

EVIDENCE FROM VIETNAM

M = 3.02

"Am I good enough?" is the number one stress for 409 first-year medical students in Ho Chi Minh City. Study workload is much lower, at M = 1.86.

Nguyen et al. (2024)

SOLUTIONS

Change how students compare, not the students

> *Having a hard time at the start of university is normal and it passes. It does not mean you do not belong.*

PROVEN

Belonging exercise

One session where students read that early self-doubt is normal, then write the same idea in their own words.

SUPPORT

Peer mentoring

Older students talk openly about their own hard times, so first-years see the real picture.

PREVENTION

Digital literacy

Teaching students that social media shows only the best moments, not normal life.

Walton, G. M., & Cohen, G. L. (2011). A brief social-belonging intervention. *Science, 331*(6023), 1447–1451.

SCHEDULE

Eight weeks, four steps

WEEKS	STEP	RESULT
1–2	Reading and questionnaire	Read seven studies, write and test the questionnaire
3–5	Collect data	Get 200 survey answers and 12 to 15 interviews
6–7	Analyse and write	Run the statistics, group the interview answers, write the draft
8	Finish	Submit the final report and present it

CONCLUSION

Peer pressure is hard, but with the right support it can help students grow

Comparing yourself is normal in the first year and can push you forward. It becomes harmful when students believe everyone else is doing much better than they really are. That belief is what a belonging exercise can fix.

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Thank you. Questions welcome.